

ART AND CULTURE



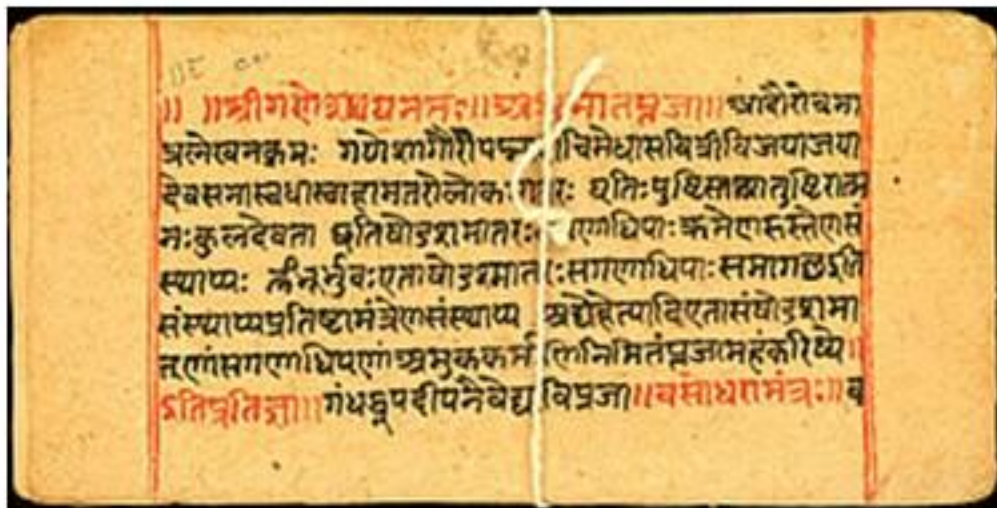
LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

MODULE – 3



IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES



- 1 Ancient Indian literature defies common perception that it was confined to sacred texts like the Vedas and the Upanishads.
- 2 There is a lot of literature in Prakrit, which is full of realism and moral values without religious connotations being attached to it.
- 3 The most popular set of works from ancient period are the Vedas - sacred texts used in religious rituals as well as in daily situations.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS



- 1 The Vedas can be said to be the most important scriptures of Hinduism as they contain the **central canons** of the **Hindu philosophy**.

- 2 The word Veda is derived from the root word '**vid**' or **knowledge** or **wisdom**.
- 3 Thus, Vedas were considered as scriptures containing the **sum total** of the **knowledge** of the people.
- 4 Further, the word 'Vid' also refers to the knowledge which could **illuminate the path in the darkness** (of ignorance), eventually leading to salvation.
- 5 It is written in **highly stylised poetic style** and the language is full of symbols.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS



- 6 The Vedas were initially handed down orally by generations of Brahmin families and finally it got codified in and around 1000 BC.

- 7 In the Hindu tradition, they are considered sacred because they are the divine revelations, which are determined by gods to guide humans eternally.

- 8 They also have larger implications on our lives as they treat the universe and its inhabitants as one big family and preach Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam.

- 9 Historically, they are said to have been composed between 1500 BCE to 600 BCE.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS



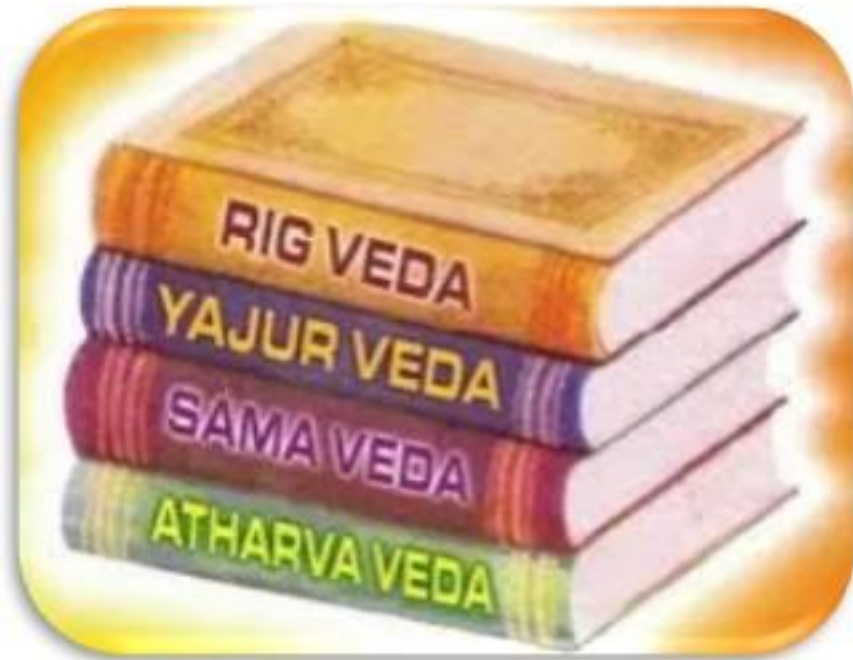
10 However, recent researchers particularly those based on astronomical dating of events described therein, attribute them to be of earlier origin although a formal compilation/categorization could have occurred later.

11 The six system of Hindu philosophy – **Nyaya, Vaisesika, Sankhya, Yoga, Purva Mimamsa, and Vedanta** (discussed later) – also accept the authority of the Vedas.

12 These were **composed in Sanskrit** and their study was largely limited to the Brahmins.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS



- 13 The Vedas are four in number: the Rigveda, the Yajurveda, the Samaveda, and the Atharvaveda.
- 14 Each of these consists of and includes the Samhitas, the Brahmanas, the Aranyakas, and the Upanishads, as separate parts or layers of the Vedas.
- 15 These are mostly written by Vedic Seer and poets called Rishis, who envisioned the cosmic mysteries and wrote them in the form of Sanskrit poetry.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS

1

RIGVEDA

1

The Rigveda is oldest of all the Vedas. Thus, it is the most ancient of the Hindu scriptures.

2

It is a collection of hymns or sukta (1028 in number) for propitiation of various deities.

3

The focus of this Veda is on hymns or verses for worship of Gods.

4

The text is organized in 10 books known as **Mandalas**.

7

Most of the hymns concentrate on the themes of life, death, creation, sacrifice and for seeking godly pleasure or soma.

6

The entire Rig vedic hymns are dedicated to several deities in particular to their chief deity, **Indra**.

5

The earliest deities were the various elements of nature (viz. Agni, Indra, Varun, Soma, etc.).



IMPORTANT UPANISHAD-
AITERYA UPANISHAD

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS

2

YAJURVEDA

- 1 The name “Yajur” means sacrifices and Yajurveda is a compilation of verses or mantras invoked or chanted in various rituals/offering by the priests.



- 2 Thus, it prescribed the modalities for conduct of different yajnas and rituals.
- 3 It has 6 Upanishads in total- Brihadaranyaka, Maitri, Isha, Katha, Shvetashvatara and Taittiriya
- 4 The earlier portion of Yajurveda (the Samhita) contains nearly 1875 shlokas.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS

3

SAMAVEDA



- 1 Samaveda has been named after Saman meaning melody and the Samaveda is a **book of chants and hymns notated as melodies.**

- 2 It is the third Veda and shortest in terms of mantras, containing 1874 mantras in total.

- 3 Many of its verses are derived from the Rigveda which are set in form of musical notation.

- 4 It has two major parts. These include melody collections in the **first part (Gana)** and the **second part contains the verses (Archika book).**

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS

3

SAMAVEDA



IMPORTANT UPANISHAD-
CHANDOGYA & KENA

5

The melody in the first part corresponds to the verse in the second part.

6

Thus, the roots of Indian music are contained in Samaveda.

7

It also contains the two important Upanishads – the Chandogya Upanishad and Kena Upanishad.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

THE VEDAS

4

ATHARVAVEDA

- 1 The Atharvaveda is the last of the Vedas and this also known as **Brahma Veda**.
- 2 The name of this Veda is derived from the word '**Atharvanas**' implying **procedures for everyday life**.
- 3 While, it is mostly concerned with peace and prosperity of the human society and covers all aspects of a man's daily life, it **specifically focuses on treatment of several ailments**.

- 4 Thus, this Veda contained knowledge having application in **daily life ranging from medicine to other physical sciences**. However, some also interpret it to be a book of magical spells or formulae, the veracity of this argument is much debated.
- 5 This Veda has nearly 730 hymns and includes **Mundaka, Mandukya, and Prashana Upanishads** as a part of it.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

1

SAMHITAS



- 1 The Samhitas are the first of the four parts of the Vedas (also referred as the first layer).

- 2 They are also referred as the 'Mantra' as they are a compilation of Mantras or sacred chants and incantations.

- 3 These chants were invoked for appeasement of elements of nature and deities.

- 4 The Samhitas are also known by the Veda to which it belonged, viz. Rigveda Samhita or the 'Rig-Samhita'.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

1

SAMHITAS

5 As the Samhitas, along with the next part of the Vedas, viz. the Brahmanas, contain ritual instructions.

6 They are together referred to as the '**Karma Kanda**' or literally the 'action portion' of the Vedas.

7 In the Hindu school of philosophy, the Samhitas and Brahmanas put together contain the **Purva Mimamsa philosophy** named so because of its focus on the earlier (pūrva) Vedic texts like Samhitas and Brahmanas dealing with ritual actions, and similarly as Karma-Mīmāṃsā due to its focus on ritual action (karma).

8 **Vedāntic schools**, was also known as **Uttara-Mīmāṃsā** for their focus on the "later" (uttara) portions of the Vedas, the Upaniṣads.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

2

BRAHMANAS

- 1 The **second part (or second layer)** of the Vedas is referred to as the Brahmanas.
- 2 Each Veda has a Brahmana attached to it which is essentially a collection of text with **commentaries on the particular Veda**.
- 3 They are usually **a mixture of legends, facts, philosophy and detailed explanations** of Vedic rituals.
- 4 They also consist of instructions as to how to **properly conduct rituals** and enunciate the **science of sacrifice**.
- 5 They also explain the **symbolic significance of the sacred words** used in the rituals.
- 6 It is believed that with passage of time it became **imperative to explain the meaning of the Mantras** which were becoming difficult to understand for the successive generations .

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

2

BRAHMANAS

SOME EXAMPLES

- ✓ **Aitareya Brahmana** – dealing with Soma sacrifice
- ✓ **Kaushitaki Brahmana** – dealing with food sacrifice in Rigveda
- ✓ **Satapatha Brahmana** – the largest Brahmana in Yajurveda deals with Vedic rituals.

7

Hence came the Brahmanas into existence which elaborated upon their meaning and significance.

8

Thus, they were concerned with the proper performance of rituals.



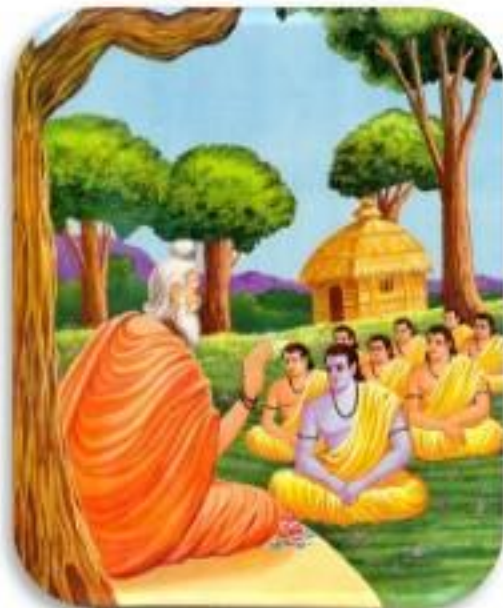
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SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

3

ARANYAKAS



- 1 The Aranyakas, the third part of the Vedas, mark a transition from a **ritualistic** to **philosophical** and **metaphysical** thoughts.

- 2 They offer explanation to the various rituals from a philosophical and different perspective .

- 3 They are the third part of the Vedas but are also considered by some **as extensions of or appendices to the Brahmanas.**

- 4 They are said to be **compilations of ritualistic information on the birth and death cycles as well as the complexity of the soul.**

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

3

ARANYAKAS

IMPORTANT ARANYAKAS

- ✓ Aitreya Aranyaka and Kaushitaki Aranyaka of Rigveda
- ✓ Taitreya Aranyaka, Katha Aranyaka of Yajurveda
- ✓ Chandoga Aranyaka, Kena Aranyaka of Samaveda
- ✓ Mundaka and Mandukya Aranyaka pertaining to Atharvaveda

5

The Aranyakas originates from Sanskrit word '**Aranya**' meaning the forest.

6

This book therefore was also called the 'forest book'.

7

The Aranyakas are believed to have been **composed by forest dwelling sages and seers**, who eschewed the rituals and emphasized more on their **spiritual and philosophical interpretation**.

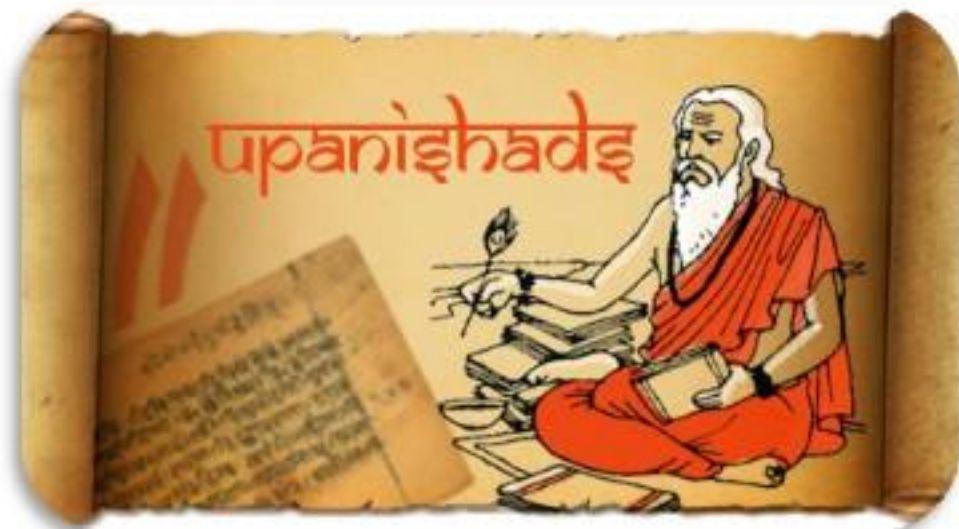
LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

4

UPANISHADS



1

The **Upanishads** are the final layer or the concluding part of the Vedas.

2

In a way they mark the highest point in the Vedic spiritual knowledge (referred as Ved-shirisha).

3

They deal with numerous metaphysical and philosophical questions such as Brahma (god), Atma (soul), their nature, and relationship which are the focus of the Upanishads.

4

As they are the concluding portion of the Vedas, they are also referred as the **Vedanta** (or the end of the Vedas) and together with the **Aranyakas** they represent the 'Jnan Kand' or the knowledge portion of the Vedas.

LANGUAGES

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

4

UPANISHADS

GURU-SHISHYA PARAMPARA



- 5 The **Upanishads** along with Brahma Sutra and the Bhagavad Gita encapsulates the **Vedanta philosophy**.

- 6 Further, the branch of philosophy '**Uttar Mimansa**' (**post analysis**) is also based on the teachings contained in Upanishads.

- 7 Thus, Upanishads were considered to be **revelatory of truth or true knowledge**.

- 8 It is also thought to mean to **sit close to a guru and to acquire knowledge**.

- 9 Interestingly, the term Upanishad or **u (at), pa (foot), ni (down) and s(h)ad (to sit)**, i.e. **to sit down near (the teacher)**, describes the text completely.

IMPORTANT HINDU SCRIPTURES

SCRIPTURES COMPRISING THE VEDAS

4

UPANISHADS



- 10** We have more than 200 known Upanishads and the teacher usually passed them down verbally to his students in the forest while they sat in front of him.

- 11** This tradition was part of the guru-shishya parampara.

- 12** The 'shishya' raises queries about the philosophical and metaphysical issues (viz. nature of cosmos, Brahma, Atman, etc.) which the 'guru' explains.

- 13** There are said to be 108 Upanishads of which ten Upanishads Chandoga, Brihdaranyaka, Aitareya, Tatkriya, Kena, Isha, Mundaka, Mandukya, katha, and Prasna are considered to be more important.

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